

Freedom of the Press

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The Fleet Street Heritage sundial stands where Richard Carlile's printing house once stood. Carlile was an important supporter of press freedom in the early 19th century. He published controversial books and newspapers and spoke openly about politics, religion, equality and social problems. Because of his views, he was often taken to court and spent more than nine years in prison. His wife, Jane, and other supporters continued his work while he was in prison. Carlile believed people should be free to express their opinions, even when those opinions challenged the government or religion.

In Carlile's time, the government could control writers through laws against sedition, blasphemy and libel. Over time, these laws were changed and eventually many were abolished. Today, freedom of the press is recognised as an important human right, although newspapers still face challenges such as expensive lawsuits, powerful owners, privacy laws and government restrictions.

The press has moved away from Fleet Street, but the street remains a symbol of journalism and free speech. The sundial reminds us that a free press helps expose wrongdoing, share information and support democracy. Press freedom is something that should be protected and valued.